

The Prodigal Son: A Story of Two Lost Brothers

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Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Ages 10-17

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories - Book 52 of 60

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aguremremu. Qidisna kab zeyinitsuhhat sebat miflat malet'yu ilom yi'amnu neberu. Yesus aguremremtaom semi'u bisne-melekatawi kiti'e zeyikone biseleste zantatat melese. Iti salisay — aziyu newih'n zetifia'n — Ferisawyan ba'ilatom kemptom zini'iqwom hat'ian ma'ire zitef'u mkhwanom kiqeli'e'yu zinebero. Misla tifu'e wedi ilom yitsuw'iwo gin misla kilte zitef'u deqi kibhal neyrwo.)

Scene 2

[PICTURE: A wealthy Middle Eastern household. An elderly father with kind eyes sits in his courtyard. Two sons stand before him — the younger one with a defiant posture, arms crossed, looking impatient and restless. The older brother stands dutiful and rigid nearby, watching with disapproval. The father's face shows deep pain beneath his calm exterior. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"There was a man who had two sons," Jesus began. The younger son approached his father with a request that would have shocked every listener: "Father, give me my share of the estate." In that culture, this was unspeakable. The inheritance was only distributed after the father's death. By asking for it now, the younger son was essentially saying, "I wish you were dead. You are worth more to me as a corpse than as a living father. Give me what I'm owed and get out of my way." Every person in Jesus' audience would have expected the father to strike his son, disown him, or drive him away in fury. But the father did something no one anticipated.

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(Kilte awedat zineberewo hade seb nebere ilu Yesus jemere. Iti ni'ishto wedi ni'abow nikulu sema'ii zesinbid hito hizu qerebe, "Abo kab nibret zigba'ani kifley habeni." Ab'ti bahli izi zeybhal'yu nebere. Wirsha dihri mot abo tiray'yu zi'idel. Hiji bimihtat'u iti ni'ishto wedi bihaqi "Moytka inte tikhewn mideleykhu. Kem hiyaw abo zeyikone kem resa ziyada titiqimeni. Zigba'ani habeni kab mendedey witsa'e" yibil nebere. Ab

*te'azebit'i Yesus zinebere kulu seb abo niwed'u kiwqi'o kibariro wey biqut'a kisego
tetsbiyu neyru kikhewn alewo. Gin abo zikhone seb zeytetsbeye gebere.)*

Scene 3

[PICTURE: The father with tears in his eyes, slowly dividing his property — handing scrolls and a bag of coins to his younger son. His hands tremble slightly. The younger son grabs eagerly without looking at his father's face. The older brother watches from the doorway, arms folded, jaw tight with resentment. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The father divided his property between them. He gave the younger son his share — roughly one-third of everything he owned. No argument. No lecture. No conditions. This reveals something profound about the heart of God: He respects human freedom, even when that freedom is used to reject Him. God does not force anyone to stay. He does not manipulate, guilt, or coerce. Love, by its very nature, must allow the beloved to walk away. A love that imprisons is not love at all — it is control. The father's silence was not indifference; it was the most painful expression of love imaginable. He released his son into the consequences of his own choices, knowing full well what was coming.

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(Abo nibret'u ab mengo'om ameqaqele. Ni'ishto wedi kiflu habo — bigimit siso nay kulu zinebero. Wala hanti kiti'e yelen. Sibket yelen. Qidme-kunet yelen. Izi biza'iba libi Amlak amiq neger yigelts: natsinet seb yikhibir'yu natsinet ni'a'u kintseg mis zitiqemelu'wun. Amlak nizikhone seb kitsenhi ayigididin'yu. Ayitsawtin ayigefifin

*ayigihisin'yu. Fiqrî bibahri'u neti zifetwo kikheyid kifeqid alewo. Zi'asir fiqrî fiqrî
ayikonen — miqutstsir'yu. Siqita abo gideleinynet ayneberen; kihiseb zike'al aziyu
ziqenzuw nay fiqrî miglats nebere. Niwed'u nab nay ba'ilu mircha sa'ibenat legeqo
intay kem zimets'e fitsum felitu.)*

Scene 4

[PICTURE: The younger son walking away on a dusty road, a large bag of money over his shoulder, not looking back. Behind him, the father stands at the gate of the family compound, one hand on the doorpost, watching his son disappear into the distance. The road stretches toward a distant city. Morning light casts a long shadow of the departing son. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Not long after that, the younger son got together all he had, set off for a distant country." He didn't just leave — he went as far as possible. The "distant country" represents more than geography; it represents the human desire to escape accountability, to be free from any authority, to write our own rules. Every teenager who has felt suffocated by family expectations understands this impulse. The allure is intoxicating: no curfew, no rules, no one watching, no one judging. Total autonomy. But what feels like freedom is actually the beginning of a prison. Autonomy without wisdom is simply a longer leash attached to self-destruction.

[illegible]

(*Dihri qurub gize iti n'Ishto wedi kulu zinebero akibu nab rihiq hager tegua'ize. Kikheyid tiray zeyikone kisab zikhe'ale rihiqu kede. "Rihiq hager" kab ji'ografi nila'ili tiwki'l'ya; kab halafinet mihdam kab zikhone siltan natsa mkhwan nay ba'ilna higi mitsiaf zibil nay seb dilet tiwki'l'ya. Bititsbitatat sidra zitehaniqe zitesmi'o kulu*

meni'isey nezi dirkhit'zi yird'ao'yu. Sihbet'u aziyu hayal'yu: wala hade nay mimilas gize yelen highi yelen zi'izeb yelen zifrid yelen. Milu'e ri'ise-mihdera. Gin kem natsinet zisimiyo bihaqi nay bet ma'iserti mejemerta'yu. Bizey tibeb ri'ise-mihdera ab ri'ise-mitifa'e zite'asere newih gemed tiray'yu.)

Scene 5

[PICTURE: The younger son in a lavish foreign city — banquet tables overflowing with food and wine, flashy companions surrounding him, musicians playing, dancing women, people flattering him. He throws gold coins carelessly. His smile is wide but his eyes are empty. The city architecture is grand and pagan. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"There he squandered his wealth in wild living." The Greek word for "squandered" means to scatter, to throw to the wind. He didn't invest poorly or make a few bad decisions — he deliberately, recklessly poured out everything his father had spent a lifetime building. Wild living: parties, excess, people who loved his money but cared nothing for his soul. This is the seduction of sin — it never advertises its end. Addiction doesn't show you the hospital bed. Lust doesn't show you the shattered relationships. Greed doesn't show you the emptiness at the top. Sin always promises freedom and delivers chains. Every "friend" at the party was actually a vulture, waiting for the money to run out.

[illegible]

(Ab'u habt'u bizey sir'at anebabra beteno. Iti nay Grikhh qal "betene" malet mibtan ninifas midribay malet'yu. Bikhu'e ayweferen wey qurub hima qas wisanetat ayweseden — abow milu'e idme'u kihantsho zitsenhe kulu biflat bizey tinqaqe afiseso. Zeyisru'e anebabra, ba'iltat mili'awal qenzebu zifetiww qin ninefsu wala hanti zeyqidesu sebat.

Izi nay hati'at misihab'yu — fitsamea fetsima aytewsiwisin'ya. Sus neti nay hospital arat ayteri'iyekan'ya. Fitiwet netom zitesababeru rikibat ayteri'iyekan'ya. Sisi'e neti ab la'ili zelo badonet ayteri'iyekan'ya. Hati'at kulu gize natsinet titesfuw seniselet terikib. Ab ba'ilti zinebere kulu "arki" bihaqi genzeb kiwda'e zitsibe amora'yu neyru.)

Scene 6

[PICTURE: The same city now looks barren and harsh. Drought has hit — dead crops in fields, empty market stalls, desperate people fighting over scraps. The younger son sits alone on a dusty street corner, his fine clothes now torn and dirty, his money pouch completely empty and turned inside out. Former friends walk past ignoring him. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"After he had spent everything, there was a severe famine in that whole country, and he began to be in need." Notice the sequence: first he emptied himself, then the external crisis hit. When you have destroyed your inner resources — your character, your relationships, your integrity — you have nothing left when life's inevitable storms arrive. The famine didn't cause his problem; it exposed it. He had been spiritually bankrupt long before he became financially bankrupt. And where were all those "friends" now? Gone. Every single one. The people who drank his wine and praised his generosity vanished the moment his usefulness ended. Sin always leaves you alone.

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(Kulu dihri miwda'u ab milu'e'ta hager birtu'e tmet kone, kisi'in'wun jemere. Neti qidme-tekhetel astebhil, qidim niba'ilu atife'a dihri'u nay dege qiluwwaw weredo. Nay wishti habitikha — bahriyatka rikibatka qiniinakha — mis afireska zeyterfii may-bred hiwet mis zimets'e wala hanti ayiterifekam'yu. Tmet tsegemu ayemtsi'on, qele'o de'a. Nay genzeb dikhham qidmi mkhwanu kab newih menfesawi dikhham'yu neyru.

Kulom "a'irukh""ke hiji abey neberu? Tefi'om. Kulom kisab hade. Weynu zisteyu legesinet'u zine'adu sebat tiqimu mis tewedae kulom tefiu. Hati'at kulu gize beynkha'ya tigidifeka.)

Scene 7

[PICTURE: The younger son in absolute degradation — filthy, barefoot, ribs showing through torn clothing, surrounded by pigs in a muddy pen. He reaches toward the pig food (carob pods) with desperate hunger. His face shows complete humiliation and despair. A foreign farmer watches him coldly from a distance. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"So he went and hired himself out to a citizen of that country, who sent him to his fields to feed pigs." For a Jewish audience, this was rock bottom. Pigs were unclean animals — forbidden, detestable. A Jewish son of a wealthy landowner, now slopping pig feed in a Gentile's field. Every shred of dignity, identity, and heritage stripped away. "He longed to fill his stomach with the pods that the pigs were eating, but no one gave him anything." He had fallen lower than animals. The pigs were eating better than he was. The son who demanded his inheritance early now envied the diet of unclean beasts. This is where rebellion always ends — not at the party, but in the pigsty.

[illegible]

(Keydu nab hade zega nay'ta hager tetsenibere nisu dima hasematat kigwasi nab grat'u sededoo. Ni'Ayhud te'azabi izi zi'amique widqet'yu neyru. Hasematat zeyinitsh zitekelkele zitseyyef insisa'yu neyru. Nay habtam balabat Ayhudawi wedi hiji ab nay

Ahzab seb grat nay hasam migbi yiqeba alo. Kulu qurtsi kibri aninat wirsha teqentitu. Hasematat zibeli'o zinebera nay harobi fire kebd'u kimle'e temeneye gin zikhone seb wala hanti ayhahon. Kab insisa bitahti wediqu nebere. Hasematat kab'u nila'ili'yom zibli'u neyrom. Wirishu qeltifu zihatete wedi hiji nay zeyinitsuhhat insisa migbi qene'o. Iliwet kulu gize ab'zi'ya tiwda'e — ab ba'ilti zeyikone ab dembe hasam.)

Scene 8

[PICTURE: The younger son sitting alone in the pigsty at dawn. A shaft of morning light breaks through clouds above him. His head is bowed, hands on his knees. His expression is changing — from despair to dawning realization. A thought bubble or inner light shows his father's house, where even servants eat bread. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"When he came to his senses, he said, 'How many of my father's hired servants have food to spare, and here I am starving to death!'" This is the turning point — "he came to his senses." The original Greek literally means "he came to himself." Sin takes us out of ourselves; repentance is coming home to who we truly are. He finally saw reality clearly: even the lowest servants in his father's house lived better than this. This moment of honest self-assessment is where all genuine transformation begins. Not at an emotional altar call, not under pressure from others, but in the quiet devastation of hitting bottom and finally admitting the truth: "I did this to myself. The life I chose is destroying me."

[illegible]

(Nab ri'isu mis temelesa kemzi bele, "Kindey'yom nay aboy teqeyaro ziterefom injera zeleWom ane gin ab'zi bitmet yimewt alekhu!" Izi nay miqiyar netbi'yu — "nab ri'isu temelesa." Nay Grikkh qedamay trigumuyu "nab ba'ilu metse" malet'yu. Hati'at kab

ri'isina tewits'ana; nisha nab bihaqi zikhonnaayo mimilas'yu. Ab meweda'ita haqi binitsur re'aye, ab bet abow zitehat'u teqeyaro'wun kab'zi nila'ili'yom zinebru neyrom. Izi nay qinue ri'ise-gimgema himot kulu haqenya lewti zijimrelu'yu. Ab simi'itawi tsewa'ita zeyikone bitseyiti kal'ot zeyikone ab hadi'e nay amiqe widqet iniwet bimeweda'ita haqi mi'iman'yu: "Niba'iley'ye geyreyo. Zimeretsikhwa hiwet tetif'ani ala.")

*kem zelo astebhil — nigdi yilemamedalo. Nay nigdi qidme-hasab yidalo alo:
"Nimigibey kiserih'ye. Kimles kiserih'ye. Sirah tiray habeni." Izi gena libi abow kem
zeyirda'o yigelts. Fiqri kisireihalu alewo miqibal fitsame yihatit qidmi zikhone miqibal
biq'u'inet'u kireagits alewo yibil yihasib'yu. Kidrader de'a'mber tsega biqelilu kiqibel
ayihashbin'yu. Mebzahtna ni'Amlak liki'e kemzi niqerbo — "Zihaysh kikhewn'ye
abirtie'e kits'ir'ye kitihitefeka'ye." Gin tsega kisireihalu ayike'alin'yu. Tsega zigebro
nisu'yu.)*

Scene 10

[PICTURE: A long dusty road stretching toward a distant estate on a hill. A tiny figure — the younger son, ragged and thin — walks slowly homeward. On the rooftop terrace of the estate, an elderly father stands scanning the horizon, hand shielding his eyes from the sun, as he has done every single day since his son left. His posture shows yearning and hope. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him." This single sentence contains the entire gospel. The father saw him "while still a long way off" — which means the father was watching. Every day. Scanning the horizon. Waiting. Hoping. Never giving up. The son thought he needed to arrive, clean up, present his speech, and earn his way back. But the father's eyes were already searching for him before he even got close. This is the heart of God — He doesn't wait for us to get our lives together before He looks our way. He is already watching for us while we are still far off, still broken, still smelling of the pigsty. His love precedes our repentance.

[illegible]

(Gena rihiqu kelo gin abow re'ayo. Iza hanti hareg milu'e wengel tihiz'ya. Abo "gena rihiqu kelo" re'ayo — malet abo yitimit nebere. Kulu me'alti. Nab darcha yitimit. Yitsbe. Tesfa yigebir. Fetsimu tesfa ayiqortsn. Wedi kibetsih kitseriy nigigru kiqrib kimles kiserih aleni ilu yihasis nebere. Gin a'inti abo diro qidmi miqirabu yidilyo neyren. Izi libi Amlak'yu — hiwetna kintsirare qidmi nabana mitimatu ayitsben'yu.

*Gena rihiqna kelena gena sebirna gena nay dembe hasam shita hizna kelena diro
yidilena'yu zelo. Fiqiru ninishana yiqidim.)*

*misihab a'igarika miqila'e yihatit — niderja zelewō aregawī wīrdet'yu. Gīn izi abo
bikhibru aytegedesen. Fiqīru niwed'u kulu mahberawī sir'at atifi'u. Goyeye. BiGrikhh
"mihret" zibil qal ami'utu tegalebet'e malet'yu — niba'ilu kihizo zeyikhil akalawī
simi'itawī fiqri'yu. Ab ma'itsho idu atamiru ayitsenihon. Wedu kizihl ayegeddon.
Wedu kishifno zeykhil rihqet kishifin goyeye. Izi tsega'yu — Amlak gena himuqat
kelena gena zeybeqi'e nigigrina nilemamed kelena gena qitsiat nitsbe kelena nabana
yigoy.)*

Scene 12

[PICTURE: The father embracing his filthy, pig-smelling son tightly, not caring about the dirt transferring to his fine robes. The son's face is buried in his father's shoulder, weeping. His mouth is open, trying to speak his rehearsed words. The father's embrace is so tight and immediate that the son can barely get words out. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"The son said to him, 'Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son.'" He started his rehearsed speech — but notice something crucial. He never finished it. His prepared script included "make me like one of your hired servants," but the father interrupted him. He never got to the part about earning his way back, about working for his food, about becoming a servant instead of a son. The father's embrace swallowed his negotiation. Grace interrupted his performance. This is what God does — He cuts us off mid-excuse, mid-negotiation, mid-attempt-to-earn-it, and simply holds us. You don't need to finish your speech. You just need to come home.

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(Wedi dima "Abo nisemay'n ni'akha'n hatie'lekhu. Degim wedkha kibhal ayigiba'anin'yu" belo. Zilemamedo nigir jemere — gin wesani neger astebhil. Fetsimu ayweda'on. Zitedalewe tsihuf'u "kem hade teqeyarokha gibereni" zibil yihiz neyru gin abo aqwaretsoo. Nay mimilas misrah migib'u misrah ab kindi wedi teqeyaro mkhwan kifil fetsimu ayibetsiho'n. Hiqufa abo nidirdiru wehato. Tsega nifitsame'u

*aqwaretseeto. Amlak zigebro izi'yu — ab ma'ikel mihlela ab ma'ikel dirdir ab ma'ikel
kinrekhibo mifitan aqwarits'u biqelilu yihizena. Nigigirka kitwdaie ayedliye kan'yu.
Nab gezakha kitimtsi'e tiray'yu zedli.)*

Scene 13

[PICTURE: The father calling out orders to his servants with joyful urgency. One servant brings the finest robe — long, ornate, purple and gold. Another carries a signet ring on a cushion. A third kneels with new leather sandals. The son stands overwhelmed, tears streaming, as his filthy rags are being replaced with symbols of full sonship. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But the father said to his servants, 'Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet.'" Every item is deliberate and loaded with meaning. The ROBE — not a servant's tunic but the best robe, the father's own robe, symbolizing complete restoration of honor and identity. The RING — a signet ring, representing authority and family membership. With this ring, the son could conduct business in the father's name. The SANDALS — servants went barefoot; only sons wore shoes. These three gifts declared to everyone present: "This is not a hired servant returning to work. This is my SON coming home." No probation period. No trial run. No earning it back. Full, immediate, unconditional restoration.

[illegible]

(Abo gin nigiziu'u "Qeltifkhum! Zibeletse khidan amtsi'ikhum albiswo. Qelebet ab idu sa'ini ab a'igaru giberu" bele. Kulu neger ilama zelew'o'n trigum zihizen'yu. Khidan — nay teqeyaro khidan zeyikone zibeletse khidan nay abo ba'ilu khidan milu'e mihidas kibir'n aninetT'n ziwkil. Qelebet — nay mahtem qelebet siltan'n abalnet sidra'n ziwkil. Beza qelebet wedi bisim abow nigdi kigebir yikhil'yu neyru. Sa'ini — gizu'at chama ayilebsun'yom; deqi tiray'yom chama zilebsu. Izen seleste wihbit'o nikulu zinebere seb aweja: "Izi kisirih zitemelese teqeyaro ayikonen. Nab geziu zimets'e zelo wedey'yu." Wala hanti nay fetene gize yelen. Nay miftan gize yelen. Kitimliso misrah yelen. Milu'e qiltuf bizay qidme-kunet mihidas.)

(Neti zisemene bikhura amtsi'ikhum hiredu. Nibla'e nihigoos. Mikiniyatu izi wedey moytu neyru hiyiwi dima koynu; tefi'u neyru terekhibu dima! Zisemene bikhura ni'aziyu abeyt'i be'alat'yu zi'iqeb — milu'e adi ke'inigil yikhil'yu neyru. Izi nay bihti nay sidra dirar ayneberen; hizibawi nay higoos awaj nebere. Qalat abo are'a'iyau yigeltsu: "Moytu'n hiyiw'n tefi'u'n terekhibu'n." Ni'abo wedu misi'an kem mot ba'ilu'yu neyru. Mimilas kem tinsa'e tesemi'o. "Izi teqeyaro" wey "izi nay qedem wedi" ayibelen — "izi wedey" bele. Waninet. Abalnet. Zeyteqeyere aninat. Hati'at wedi niwildinetu ayiqeyeron. Bahriyu ab bet abo zinebero temekuro qeyero gin ab libi abo zinebero bota fetsimu ayiqeyeron.)

Scene 15

[PICTURE: The older brother returning from the fields at dusk, sweaty and tired from hard work. He carries farming tools over his shoulder. In the background, the family estate is lit up with torches and lanterns, sounds of music and celebration drifting toward him. His face shows confusion turning to suspicion. A servant runs toward him to explain. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Meanwhile, the older son was in the field. When he came near the house, he heard music and dancing. So he called one of the servants and asked him what was going on." Now the story takes its devastating turn. Everyone focuses on the younger son's rebellion, but Jesus' real target in this parable was standing right in front of Him — the Pharisees, the older brothers. The older son had been in the field, working. Always working. Dutiful, responsible, obedient — at least externally. He didn't know about the celebration because no one told him, which suggests something about his relationship with the household. He was physically present but relationally distant. He lived in his father's house but didn't share his father's heart.

(Ab'zi gize'zi iti abi wed'u ab grat nebere. Nab geza mis qerebe muziqan sa'isi'it'n semi'e. Hade kab gizu'at tsewiu intay kem zikhewn zelo hatetoo. Hiji zanta nab zetifia quliqu'l tiqiyir. Kulu seb ab iliwet ni'ishto wedi'yu zetekur gin haqenya ilama

Yesus ab'zi misla qidmi'u dew ilom neyrom — Ferisawyan abeyti ahwat. Abi wedi ab grat yiserih nebere. Kulu gize yiserih. Tegbarawi halafnetawi te'azazi — biwihidu bigdam. Biza'iba be'al ayifeletn mikiniyatu zikhone ayinegeroon zikhone dima biza'iba mis sidra zinebero rikib yinegir'yu. Bi'akal neyru birikib gin rihiqu neyru. Ab bet abow yinebir neyru gin libi abow aykefilon neyru.)

*bahli nay abo be'al mistaf mi'ibay kem nay ni'ishto wedi qedamay hito zikhbid
hizibawi tserfi'yu neyru. Kilti'om awedat ni'abo'om bihizbi ahiferu. Hade bi'iliwet hade
biri'ise-tsidqi. Kemu'wun abo nay mogas zeybilu tegbar gebere — nab dege wetse.
Nay ba'ilu ba'ilti gedifu niqutue wed'u kidiliyo kede. Amlak nab alewti tiray ayigoyin;
netom haymanotawiyen moralawiyen mi'izazom gele kem zetreform zihasibu abeyti
ahwat'wun yisi'ibom'yu.)*

(Nisu gin ni'abow "Ri'a! Kulu'zen ametat barya koyne serihelka ti'izazka'wun fetsime ayitihaskun. Gin ni'ay mis a'irukhitey kihigoos wala hanti mahsi'e ayhahkanin" ilu melese. Neti zigelts qwanqwa sima'e: "Barya koyne serihelka." "Agelgile" wey "misakha nebire" zeyikone — barya koyne. Mis abow zinebero rikib kem gidud sirah de'a'mber kem fiqri ayiri'iyon neyru. "Ti'izazka fetsime ayitihaskun." Nay fitsum mi'izazu netbi yihiz neyru. "Wala hanti ayhahkanin." Kibri zeytewehabo asbi zeyrekhebe ziterese'e tesemi'iwo. Izi abi haw nay fitsame-zitemeserete haymanot libi yigelts: "Kulu liki'e geyre gin ni'a'u intay rekhebku?" Bifiqri zeyikone ni'asbi de'ayu zegelgil neyru. Mi'izazu rikib zeyikone nigdi nebere.)

rikib abiyu. "Amenazir" wun wesekhe — Yesus ab zanta fetsimu zeyiteqeso zirzir. Abi haw ni'ishto zidedede kimesil hati'at fetiru. Ri'ise-tsadiqan kulu gize nay ba'ilom merirnet nimifitah nay kal'ot widqet ya'ibiywo'yom. Tir'anu dima aziyu amiqe qusli yigelts: "Ni'a'u tehigooselu ni'ay gin fetsimka aytehogoskaleyn." Abi haw bibikhura zeyikone kab haw nila'ili yigiba'o ilu sile zi'amene'yu ziqot'e'e. Tsibuq bahri'u ziyada kitreifo'yu zinebero ma'ire fiqri zeyikone.)

(Wedey abo bele "niskha kulu gize misay ikha kulu zeleni dima natka'yu." Nay abo melsi bilewahinet'u zidenits'yu. Wala hanti ginhat qut'a yelen — bifiqri zitezerbe haqi tiray. "Kulu gize misay ikha" — hilawiey kitrekhibo kiserih ayedliye kan neyru kab qedem neyruka'yu. "Kulu zeleni natka'yu" — nimahsi'e barya kikhewn ayedliye kan neyru mikiniyatu milu'e nibret diro natka'yu neyru. Nikulu mibitsah neyruka gin fetsimka ayiteqemkalu'n. Hazen abi haw ab bizhi nibru gin dikhnet zitemekore mkhwanu'yu. Fiqri abo neyru gin fetsimu ayitegebelon. Natsa neyru gin kem barya nebere. Izi ni'asirtetat ametat ni'Amlak zegelgelu gin fiqiru fetsimom zeyitemekoru haymanotawiyen sebat zetifia'e si'ili'yu — miqibal tiray ab kindi misrah aziyom tetsemido sile zikhonu.)

Scene 20

[PICTURE: The father pleading with the older son to come inside to the celebration. The door to the feast is wide open — light, warmth, and joy streaming out. The older son stands at the threshold, torn between his pride and the invitation. His foot is half-turned away. The father's hand reaches for him. The choice hangs in the air. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"But we had to celebrate and be glad, because this brother of yours was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found." The father gently corrects the older son: "this BROTHER of yours" — not "this son of mine" but YOUR brother. You are connected whether you like it or not. And then the story simply... ends. Jesus never tells us whether the older brother went in. The parable is deliberately unfinished because Jesus was speaking directly to the Pharisees — and the question was for THEM. Will you come in to the party? Will you celebrate that God welcomes sinners? Or will you stay outside in your self-righteous anger, insisting you deserve more? The story's open ending is its most powerful feature. The older brother's decision is still being made — by every religious person who hears this story.

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(Gin kinihigoos kinibe'al neyruna mikiniyatu izi hawkha moytu neyru hiyiwi koynu tefi'u neyru terekhibu dima. Abo bilewah ni'abi wedi areme: "izi hawkha" — "izi wedey" zeyikone hawkha. Fetekha tselekha te'asisirkhum ikhum. Dihri'u zanta biqelilu... tewedae. Yesus abi haw atyu do ayi'atewen fetsimu ayinegerenann. Misla bi'ilama zeyitewedae'yu mikiniyatu Yesus biqetita niFerisawyan'yu zizareb neyru — hito ni'atatom'yu neyru. Nab ba'ilti kiti'atw'do? Amlak nihati'an miqibal'u kitihigosu'do? Weyis binay ri'ise-tsidqi qut'akhum ab dege kititsenihu ziyada yigiba'akum ilkhum? Nay zanta kifut meweda'ita aziyu hayal bahriyu'yu. Wisane abi haw gena yiwsen alo — bikulu neza zanta zismi'e haymanotawi seb.)

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(Yesus zimihro zinebere zetifia'e haqi ineho: kilte mengedi mitifa'e alo. Ni'ishto wedi binitsur iliwet tefi'u — ni'abo biminitsag high bimitihas bigihud hati'at biminbar. Alem biqelilu nezi aynet mitifa'e telelyo'ya. Gin abi haw bihaymanot ma'ire tefi'u'yu neyru — kulu high hizu ab geza tsenihu kulu "liki'e" geysu gin fiqri abo fetsimu zeyitemekore mikiniyatu ni'asbi de'a'mber nirikib ayikonen zegelgil neyru. Alawi "bifitsum ayedliyenin" yibil. Haymanotawi "nabakha natey mengedi kiserih'ye" yibil. Kilti'om nay ba'ilom medihani kikhonu mifitan'yom. Kilti'om libi abo fitsum yisihitu. Kilti'om wetsa'i ba'ilti'yom ziwda'u — hade ab dembe hasam hade ab ri'ise-tsidqi nitsiline.t Yesus niFerasawyan yiblom nebere: "Kabtom hat'ian zihaysh'khum ilkhum tihasiibu? Ma'ire tefi'u ikhum. Minalbat ziyada'wun mikiniyatu kitiri'iywo'wun aytikhilun.")

(Nayza misla haqenya jigna iti zitenishe wedi zeyikone — abo'yu. Ab kulu tri'it ma'ikel'yu. Zihasi mis zikhewn'wun natsinet yihib'yu. Bizey mibqa'e ti'igisti yitsbe'n yi'izeb'n. Bizey kibri zigebebe hadimu yigoy. Bizey qidme-kunet yihidis. Niri'ise-tsadiq ni'alawi biziabo fiqri ba'ilu yisi'ibo. Izi abo Amlak'yu. Nayza zanta skandal dima fiqri Amlak nigdawi zeyimkhwanu'yu. Bifitsame kitirekhiboo aytikhilin. Biwidqet kitisi'ino aytikhilin. Nitsibuq bahri kifliet wey nihimaq bahri qitsiat miwits'ae ayikonen. Biqelilu alo — qetsali se'abi li'ul bizey kibri zigebebe natsa. Ni'ishto wedi binay teqeyaro wi'il kirekhiboo fetene. Abi wedi bimi'izaz diro rekhbiyo ilu hasebe. Kilti'om tegagiyom. Tsega ayisireihalu'n'yu. Yiqibel'yu.)

Scene 23

[PICTURE: A modern teenage scene blended with the parable's themes. On one side, a teen scrolling through social media alone, representing the "far country" of modern rebellion — isolation, empty pleasures. On the other side, a teen in church looking perfect on the outside but with chains visible on the inside, representing religious performance. In the center, a warm light representing God's grace breaks through to both. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Which son are you? Perhaps you're the younger son — running from God, family, or responsibility. Chasing freedom that turns out to be a different kind of prison. Perhaps you've already hit your pigsty moment and you're wondering if God would even take you back. Here's the answer: He's already watching. He's already waiting. He'll run to you before you can finish your excuses. Or perhaps you're the older brother — doing everything "right" but feeling empty, resentful, comparing yourself to others, angry that "bad people" seem to get grace they don't deserve. If your faith feels like slavery rather than love, if you're keeping score with God, if other people's restoration makes you angry rather than joyful — you might be standing outside the feast right now, refusing to go in. Both sons needed the same thing: to stop performing and simply receive the father's love.

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(Ayenay wedi ikha? Minalbat ni'ishto wedi ikha — kab Amlak sidra halafinet tihadim. Zitefeleyee aynet bet ma'iserti zikhonet natsinet tisi'ib. Minalbat diro ab nay dembe hasam himotka betsihka Amlak kiqebeleka'do ilka tihasis alekha. Melsi ineho: diro yitimit alo. Diro yitsbe alo. Mihlelakha qidmi miwda'ekha nabakha kigoy'yu. Wey minalbat abi haw ikha — kulu "liki'e" tigebir gin bado qirub tirekhibo niba'ilkha mis kal'ot tinetisatsir "himuqat" zeygiba'om tsega zirekhibu yimesleka ziqot'e'e. Imnetkha kem fiqri zeyikone kem bariynet zismi'aka mis Amlak netbi tihiz mis tikhewn mihidas kal'ot bihigoos zeyikone biqut'a zismi'aka mis zikhewn — hiji wetsa'i ba'ilti dew ilka kit'atu ti'abi tikhewn tikhil ikha. Kilti'om awedat hade neger neyruwom zedli: fitsame miqurats biqelilu fiqri abo miqibal.)

Scene 24

[PICTURE: The Pharisees listening to Jesus finish this parable, their faces showing mixed reactions — some convicted, some furious, some thoughtful. Jesus looks at them with compassion, not condemnation. Behind Jesus, the tax collectors and sinners who started the whole conversation are also listening, some with tears of hope. The scene captures the tension between grace and religious pride. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Jesus ended the parable staring directly at the Pharisees. The message was unmistakable: "You are the older brother. You criticize Me for eating with sinners, but you don't understand that God's heart breaks for them. Your religion has made you blind to grace. You think your obedience makes you superior, but it has actually made you just as far from the Father as the worst sinner — because you've turned love into a wage and worship into a transaction." Grace scandalizes the self-righteous. It always has. The idea that God would throw a feast for someone who wasted everything is offensive to anyone who has spent their life trying to earn what was always free. But that's exactly what makes grace so beautiful — and so dangerous to religious pride.

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*(Yesus neti misla biqetita nab Ferisawyan temitu weda'o. Mel'ikhti nitsur nebere:
"Niskhatikum abi haw ikhum. Mis hat'ian yibli'e ilkhum tiniqifuni gin libi Amlak
ni'atatom kem zisiber ayirda'akum'n'yu. Haymanotkhum nitsega awerti
geyrukhum'yu. Mi'izazkhum zibeletse yigebrekhum tihasibu gin bihaqi kab abo kem
zikhefie hatai ma'ire arhiqukhum'yu — mikiniyatu fiqri nab demewez amilkho nab
nigdi qeyirkhomo." Tsega niri'ise-tsadiqan yisekhorom'yu. Kulu gize kemu'u neyru'yu.
Amlak nikulu zibetene seb ba'ilti kem zigebir zibil hasab neti kulu gize natsa zinebere
kirekib hiwetu ahilifu zitse'are kulu seb yiskhiro'yu. Gin nitsega kindu'u tsibuu zigebro
— nihaymanotawi ti'ibit kindu'u hadgenya'wun — liki'e nisu'yu.)*

Scene 25

[PICTURE: A beautiful final image — the father's house with its door wide open, warm light flooding out into the darkness. The feast continues inside. Both the road from the far country AND the path from the field lead to the same open door. Above the door, invisible but implied, is the truth: "Come home." The image invites every viewer — rebel and religious alike — to simply walk through the door. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The door is still open. Whether you're coming from the far country of rebellion or the nearby field of religious performance, the father's invitation is the same: come in to the feast. Stop running. Stop earning. Stop comparing. Stop performing. Just come home. True repentance is not cleaning yourself up first — it's simply turning around and walking toward the father, trusting that His love will meet you before you arrive. God's party is not for the polished and the perfect; it's for the broken, the exhausted, the honest. It's for anyone willing to stop pretending and simply say, "I need You." The father is watching. The father is waiting. And when He sees you coming — no matter how far you've wandered or how long you've pretended — He will run.

በዚህ ሰዓት ስለፍታሁት በዚህ ሰዓት ስለፍታሁት በዚህ ሰዓት ስለፍታሁት
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በዚህ ሰዓት ስለፍታሁት — በዚህ ሰዓት ስለፍታሁት

(Ma'itsho gena kifut'yu. Kab rihiq hager iliwet timets'e alekha wey kab qereba grat haymanotawi fitsame idme abo hade'yu: nab ba'ilti atu. Mihadam gidef. Misrah gidef. Minitsitsir gidef. Fitsame gidef. Nab gezakha tiray mitsa'e. Haqenya nisha qidim niba'ilkha mitsray ayikonen — biqelilu mili'al nab abo mikhad'yu qidmi mibitsahka fiqiru kirekhibeka mi'iman. Ba'ilti Amlak nitsiruyan'n fitsumat'n ayikonen; nisebirat nizidekhemu niqinu'at'yu. Mimisal dew abilu "adliyen" kibil fiqadenya nizikhone'yu. Abo yitimit alo. Abo yitsbe alo. Timets'e kem zelekha mis ziri'iyeka — kindey rihiqka kindey gize temsilka bizeyegedis — kigoy'yu.)

The Moral / ቅዱስ

God's love is not transactional — it cannot be earned through performance or lost through failure. There are two ways to be lost: through open rebellion (rejecting God entirely) and through religious performance (serving God for reward rather than love). Both the rebel and the religious person miss the father's heart. True repentance is not proving yourself worthy — it is simply coming home, trusting that the Father's love will meet you before you arrive. Grace scandalizes the self-righteous because it is given freely to the undeserving. God's feast is for the broken and honest, not the polished and proud. The Father is always watching, always waiting, and always ready to run.

ቅዱስ ልብና ልብና ልብና — ቅዱስ ልብና ልብና ልብና
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Bible Verse / ቅዱስ ስላሴ ቅዱስ

"But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him." — Luke 15:20

"ቅዱስ ስላሴ ቅዱስ ስላሴ ቅዱስ ስላሴ ቅዱስ ስላሴ ቅዱስ ስላሴ
— ቅዱስ 15:20

("Gena rihiqu kelo gin abow re'ayo bimihret dima temel'a, goyyu haqifu se'amo." — Luqas 15:20)

ገገገገገ? ገገ ገገገገ "ገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገ" ገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገገገገ?
ገገገገገገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ-ገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገ?

4. Jesus deliberately left the parable unfinished — we never learn whether the older brother went inside to the feast. Why do you think Jesus ended it this way? If you were the older brother, what would it take for you to swallow your pride and join the celebration for someone you felt didn't deserve it? Think of a real situation where someone received grace that felt unfair to you.

4. ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገገ ገገገ — ገገ ገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገገ? ገገ ገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገገ? ገገገ ገገገገገገ ገገገ ገገ ገገ ገገ ገገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ

5. The parable shows two ways to be far from God: rebellion and religion. Which tendency do you lean toward — running away from God's rules entirely, or trying to earn His love through perfect behavior? How does understanding that grace is free (not earned) change the way you relate to God, to failure, and to other people who mess up?

5. ገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገ — ገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገገ ገገገገገ? ገገ ገገ (ገገገገገገ) ገገገ ገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገ ገገገገገገ?

Prayer / ቅጽ

Father God, we confess that we are both sons in this story. Part of us is the younger brother — wanting Your blessings without Your presence, chasing freedom that leads to emptiness, believing we can find life apart from You. Part of us is the older brother — serving You from duty rather than delight, keeping score, resenting the grace You show to others, turning Your love into a wage we think we've earned. Forgive us for both. We don't want to be in the far country or in the field — we want to be at Your feast, resting in Your love. Help us to stop performing and simply receive. Help us to stop running and simply come home. Teach us that Your love is not a transaction — it cannot be earned by our goodness or lost by our failure. When others receive grace, help us celebrate rather than compare. When we fall, help us remember that You are already watching, already running toward us. Thank You that You are the kind of Father who sacrifices His dignity to reach His children. We come home to You today — not with a polished speech, but with empty hands and honest hearts. In Jesus' name, Amen.

ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ
ቅጽ'ላ — ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ
ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ'ላ —
ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽ
ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽ
ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽጽ — ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽ
ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ
ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ ቅጽ
ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽጽ — ቅጽጽጽጽጽጽ ቅጽጽጽ ቅጽ ቅጽጽጽጽጽጽ

ባለቤቱም ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት
 ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት
 ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት —
 ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት ለሰው ሕይወት

(Abo Amlak abza zanta kilti'om awedat mkhwanna ni'amin. Kifalna ni'ishto
 haw'yu — bizey hilawiekha berekhetka nideli nab badonet zimrih natsinet
 nisi'ib bizey ni'akha hiwet kinrekib nikhil ilna ni'amin. Kifalna abi haw'yu —
 bitehagoos zeyikone bigidata negelgileka netbi nihiz nikhal'ot zeri'iyeka
 tsega niqeni'e fiqrikha nab rekhbibnayo zimeslena demowz niqiyro. Nikilti'u
 yiqire bilena. Ab rihiq hager wey ab grat kikhewn ayinidelin — ab ba'iltikha
 kikhewn ab fiqrikha kini'arif nideli. Fitsame tehtew abilna biqelilu kinqibel
 hagizena. Mihadam tehtew abilna nab gezana kinimts'e hagizena. Fiqrikha
 nigdi zeymkhwanu miharena — bitsibuqnetna kisireihalu wey biwidqetna
 kitife'e ayikhilin. Kal'ot tsega mis ziqibelu kinenetisatsir zeyikone kinihigoos
 hagizena. Mis niwidiq diro titimit diro nabana tigoy kem zelekha kinzikir
 hagizena. Nideqikha kitibetsih kibirikha zisiwe'e abo mkhwanka nemsgineka.
 Lomi nabakha nimts'e — bizitetereye nigir zeyikone bitiray id'n qinue lib'n.
 Bisim Yesus Amen.)

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

Book 52 of 60

Thank you for reading! We pray this story reveals to you the scandalous, pursuing, unconditional love of God — a Father who runs toward rebels and pleads with the religious, whose grace cannot be earned or lost, and whose feast is always open to anyone willing to simply come home.

በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ የተጻፈው! በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ የተጻፈው በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ
በዚ-ቅጽ ውስጥ የተጻፈው ቅጽ — በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ የተጻፈው
በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ
በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ በዚ ቅጽ ውስጥ

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